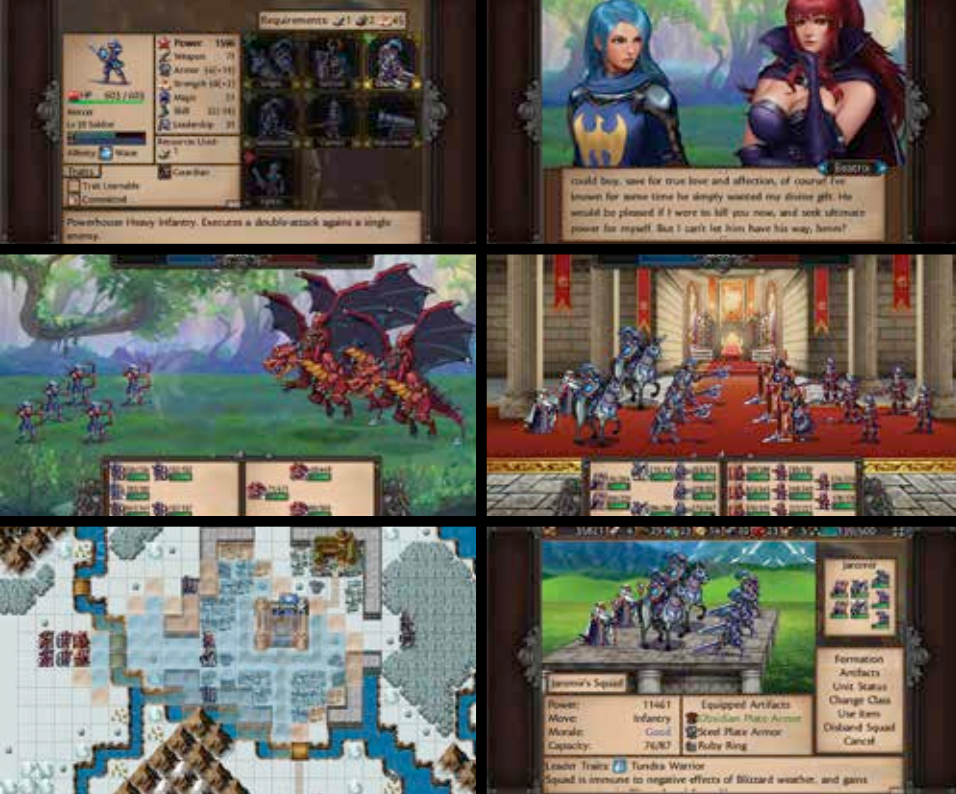




WHAT MAKES A GOOD LEADER?

But of course, no squad is complete without a leader. The leader determines how strong a squad can be. Every unit you acquire can become a leader, but how good they are depends on their leadership stat. Every unit has a cost in order to be in a squad, so your leadership stat also determines how big your squad can be. Even equipping items to a squad has a cost. Mercenaries tend to cost more, while loyal units are cheaper, understandably. However, units tend to become loyal over time.

There are specialised leaders that you acquire as your progress through, that give their squad certain benefits. The main character for instance comes with the mentorship trait, which grants bonus leadership to squadmates. This makes the main character's squad a great place to create future squad leaders. There are other specialised traits as well; General Lysander for instance, gets a discount on all gunpowder units in his squad. While you get these characters through the course of the game, there are special named mercenaries that you might get the opportunity to hire which also come with special leadership traits.

THE COST OF WAR

However, all of your customisation

and recruitment will need gold and resources. Even items (especially the powerful ones), called artefacts in the game, are pretty pricey, so you need to be careful with your spending. Keep an eye out for bazaars mid mission which have the best items and recruits, and be sure to always have gold on hand to spend at these bazaars. In addition to gold, we mentioned you need resources. In order to class up units you need certain resources, like gems for magic units, iron for infantry, horses for cavalry and so on. These resources become more specialised and rare (obsidian, sunstones etc) as you progress and unlock even more powerful classes.

FACTION LEVELS

As you progress through the story, you'll also unlock faction levels, which in turn will allow you to unlock new technologies for your army. These technologies can vary from small boosts like dealing more morale damage to enemies, to massive ones like allowing gunpowder units to shoot twice, or being able to train dragonriders. Naturally, the more powerful ones are more expensive and unlock later in the game.

Since we brought up morale, the game allows you to force enemies to surrender, if their morale is low enough. Successfully forcing a surren-

der will net you bonus gold and faction experience at the end of a level, so always try to force surrender whenever possible.

That about covers the gist of the gameplay elements in Symphony of War. There's a lot more depth to the game, but we don't have the real estate to explain all of it here. Besides, it's best experienced in-person. While it may all seem complicated, it's pretty easy to grasp. We didn't think we'd need to break down the controls or anything; it's fairly straightforward. Plus, the game does a good job of easing you into the game's core mechanics.

STORY

The story is probably the weakest aspect of Symphony of War. Not to say that it's horrible or anything, it's just as generic as they come. End of the world, yada yada yada, chosen one, yada yada yada, angelic powers yada yada yada. The name has Nephilim in it, if that didn't give it away.

You've got bits of conversation between missions, which take the story forward, and some optional conversations between the companions travelling with you. We say optional because you're free to skip them completely and can still finish the game no problem. It'll probably affect some of the text down the line but you won't miss anything in terms of gameplay. It's just an opportunity for the characters to showcase some personality. You can form bonds between characters and even pursue romances here, which will provide a small buff while on the field. It's pretty negligible though.

VERDICT

So yes, Symphony of War: The Nephilim Saga did indeed scratch my SRPG itch. It certainly has its flaws, but for a fresh take on a rather stagnant genre, we have no complaints overall. The game is actively getting updates with balance patches for underused and overpowered classes, the potential for replayability is pretty solid. Certainly give this a try if you're a fan of SRPGs. *